faster than I have in years, my body feeding off its input and adapting into an evolved state of athleticism I have never reached before.

Maybe most importantly, I am also finding that cricket keeps asking new questions, presenting new challenges, and in turn, now that the self-doubt and self-worth paranoia that plagued me in the early part of my career are quietened, I am beginning to just enjoy it. We are at Headingley for the Sri Lanka series that forms half of the summer. When we get there, Broady and I have the sudden realisation that we both always bowl from the same end and both of us struggle. I would usually run downhill and Broady would start up the hill at the Football Ground End. It's never really worked. We shrug at each other before play – is it worth swapping ends?

Jonny Bairstow has batted brilliantly on a difficult pitch, puffing his chest out in his trademark way and putting the bad balls away. I've watched and waited, trying to calculate what the difference will be from the other end. Up the hill, running in, it encourages me to run faster, to surge myself against the current. Where the opposite end at Headingley can con you into bowling too full, it's the opposite up the hill. It's a battle against bowling slightly too short. The ball feels like it kicks off the surface more though and I enjoy all the opposing causes and effects it creates.

To Kaushal Silva, I get the ball to kick from just back of a length. He edges behind to Bairstow. Then I'm pushing the ball into Angelo Mathews' pads, angling in, trapping him LBW. It's all about patiently probing a similar line, little variations, not allowing them any respite whatsoever. To Dasun Shanaka, I get the ball to shape away from the right-hander, leaving him with the ball hanging. Then Rangana Herath, the same to a left-hander. Finally, Shaminda Eranga, a reviewed caught behind. They are all out for 91 and I have a five-for to my name. Cooky asks if I feel like I can bowl again, putting them in to follow on. He doesn't even need an answer. Not even a day later, I have another five wickets, steering England to an innings victory. I've never felt stronger, running up the hill, running so hard it almost feels like I'm running away from something – maybe all the retirement questions, still against the tide, still walking out of somewhere, still getting to some place new, still plenty of cricket to play, no matter what they all say.

A year later, I'll take my 500th wicket for England at 35 years old, before a week later recording career best innings figures of 7–42 against the